



Study in the USA: How to Rent an Apartment as an International Student

Published on September 17, 2025 by [Kaitlyn Neitman](#)

Key takeaways:

- You can rent an apartment as an international student in the U.S., but may need a co-signer or guarantor.
- Gather required documents early, including your passport, visa, and proof of enrollment.
- Create a budget that covers rent, utilities, food, transportation, and personal expenses.
- Research neighborhoods, know your tenant rights, and read your lease carefully before signing.

Beginning the search for [off-campus housing](#) is a thrilling adventure for any college student, but for international students, renting in the United States for the first time can be especially intimidating. Luckily, the excited glow you've been sporting from your acceptance letter doesn't have to be dulled by nerves.

With so many great universities in the United States, you could be looking for an apartment anywhere between [New York, NY](#) and [San Francisco, CA](#). From knowing what documents you'll need, to understanding the [rental process](#), to finding the perfect apartment near your new campus, this Redfin real estate guide is here to help you rent an apartment as an international student.

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Can I rent an apartment as an international student?

Yes, you can rent an apartment as an international student, although you may encounter more challenges during the process. Many students moving internationally choose to live on campus or with a host family.

These options may provide more structure and support from your school's international student program. However, if living off-campus on your own is an important part of your college experience, we'll walk you through the most important steps – and important things to look out for – along the way.

>>Learn more: [Redfin's Off-Campus Living Guide](#)

How to rent an apartment as an international student

There are a lot of great [tips for first time apartment renters](#), but moving internationally requires extra planning and attention to detail throughout the process. The steps below outline the basic necessities for renting as an international student:

1. Determine a budget

Creating a realistic budget is an essential step in any home search, and is especially crucial for college students. As an international student, you'll also need to consider how [currency exchange rates](#) might affect your [cost of living](#). Look into prepaid foreign exchange (forex) cards or opening a [local bank account](#) to help manage fluctuations.

When budgeting for your cost of living, be sure to include the following:



- **Monthly rent and utilities:** Some apartments include the cost of utilities in their total monthly rent. Ask whether utilities are included to make sure you stay within your planned rent budget.
- **Internet connection:** You'll most likely need to access your coursework from home, so don't forget to add internet costs to your budget.
- **Transportation:** If your campus does not offer a transit pass or you're living far enough away to commute, be aware of local fares or costs of parking permits.
- **Groceries and food:** Consider local store prices and how often you want to go out to eat or grab a late-night study coffee when building a food budget.
- **Personal expenses:** Tuition and textbooks should be first on your overall study-abroad budget, but set aside some fun money to aid in your experience of the local culture.

2. Prepare documents in advance

Have all of your documents organized and ready to go first. Here's what you'll need to show a landlord if you're renting as an international student:

- **Proof of identity:** You typically need to show your passport or government-issued photo ID to rent an apartment in the United States.
- **Proof of enrollment:** School documents such as an official class schedule, transcript, student ID card, or enrollment verification letter can serve as proof of enrollment.
- **Valid student visa:** You'll need to obtain a [student visa](#) to both study in the U.S. and show proof of lawful presence on your rental application. Your school's international student program can help you learn more about the visa application process.
- **Proof of income or assets:** Most apartments have an [income requirement](#) for renters. This ratio is often set between 2 to 3 times the monthly rent cost. This can be a challenging hurdle for many prospective renters, and especially for college students. Getting a [co-signer](#) or [guarantor](#) will help make your application more attractive to a landlord.

3. Get a co-signer or guarantor

If you don't have a steady income or American credit, don't worry, there are still ways you can rent an apartment as an international student. In fact, most students who are just starting out with off-campus housing use a co-signer or guarantor. Both provide

financial security to landlords and assume the responsibility of paying the rent if you cannot pay yourself.

Co-signers also sign your lease, and are identified as tenants with the same legal rights to the apartment as you. They can be a [roommate or a personal contact](#), but must meet the basic requirements, such as good to excellent credit and proof of employment with a steady income. Some employers may accept co-signers, like a parent or other family member, who lives out of the country, but it's important to ask for their specific requirements upfront before getting too far in the process.

Guarantors, on the other hand, are typically a third-party service. They do not have access to the apartment, and only step in if you default on your rent. While a person you know and trust can be a guarantor, the financial requirements are much higher than those for a co-signer. Ask your landlord for their specific guarantor requirements first. Some landlords either do not accept guarantors or will only work with certain third-party companies.

4. Research the neighborhood and the property

Whether your school is near a classic [college town](#) or a major city, researching the nearest neighborhoods is essential. You might want to know the [top things to do in Boston](#) if you're Harvard-bound, but you'll also need to prepare for the competitive markets. Enlisting the help of a broker, or [rental agent](#), while not technically required, is extremely beneficial in certain cities in order to quickly find the right apartments, avoid scam listings, and get a good deal on rent costs. Be sure to budget for broker fees if you end up using a rental agent.

Regardless of where you're looking, it's always a good idea to tour the neighborhood and the property in person. Combine a campus visit with an apartment search if you're able, or request video tours from listing agents and landlords. When you do move in, take photos of everything to record the current state of the apartment. This can help you recoup some costs of your security deposit when you're ready to move out.

5. Understand your rights as a tenant

Every [renter has rights](#) that protect them on local, state, and federal levels. Familiarize yourself with both [federal tenant rights](#) and local tenant rights when you know where you'll be renting. Knowing what is protected and allowed by both you as a tenant and

your landlord will help set your expectations and provide peace of mind during your housing search and tenancy.

6. Review your lease agreement thoroughly

Your lease agreement should outline all of the information about the residence you will be renting, including:

- Names of your landlord, your co-signer or guarantor, and all tenants
- The address and condition of the property
- The duration of the lease, its beginning and end date, and renewal policy
- Agreed upon rent rate and utility costs
- Rules and policies, like quiet hours, pets, and parking
- Maintenance and repair policies
- A signature section for all parties

Thoroughly review each section [before signing the lease](#) to make sure everything aligns with what you're expecting. If you have any questions, speak to your landlord to make sure you're both on the same page before proceeding.

Where to look for off-campus housing

Your university is a great place to start your off-campus housing search. Many schools have resource pages for international students moving to the U.S. to help with documents, roommate searches, and housing searches.

Once you're ready to look for listings, use a national rental website like [Redfin](#), [ApartmentGuide](#), or [Rent.com](#). Local social media pages and neighborhood message boards can also be a good source of local listings, but be extra careful of [rental scams](#).

International student housing FAQ

How much does it cost to rent an apartment in the United States?

The [average monthly rent in the U.S. is \\$1,789](#), but the cost varies widely depending on multiple factors, such as location and type of residence. Research the neighborhoods near your campus to gain a better understanding of average local rent costs.



What documents do I need to show my landlord?

Your landlord will need to see proof of identity, enrollment, legal residency, and income. Your university should provide you with enrollment documentation and may even be able to direct you on how to [obtain a student visa](#).

Do I need a Social Security number to rent in the U.S.?

No, you don't need a Social Security number to rent in America, as you can provide other proof of identity. You will need to provide proof of legal residency, however, which your student visa will show.

What if I don't have any local credit history?

If you don't have local credit history, use a co-signer or a guarantor. Having a third party, whether it's one person or a company, to back up your rent will provide landlords with the financial reassurances they need to accept your application.

Does my co-signer or guarantor have to live in the United States?

Whether your co-signer or guarantor is required to be local is highly dependent on the landlord's policies. Many landlords do require them to be local, so ask about these details upfront to save time and prepare correctly.

Is it better to live on campus or in a homestay instead?

Renting as an international student can be a complex process, but it's not an impossible feat. While on-campus housing or homestays provide a unique level of convenience and support, you can still find a great apartment close to campus and central to exploring your new city as well. Ultimately, deciding where and how to move to the U.S. for college is a highly personal choice. It's up to you to decide what the best option will be for your situation.

International moving can be stressful, but you can do this

Housing for international students requires a bit more planning and research, but if renting an off-campus apartment is high on your college experience list, it's certainly doable. Whether you're searching for homes on Redfin with a [roommate](#) or embarking  on a solo journey, you'll be ready to rent with the steps above to guide you.

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